

GRADE 8 · READING INFORMATIONAL TEXT · RI.8.3

Two Towns, One Flood

Analyze how an informational text draws connections and distinctions between individuals, ideas, or events, including through direct comparisons, analogies, or categories.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RI.8.3: Analyze how an informational text draws connections and distinctions b...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

At grade 8, this standard asks you to notice the specific method a text uses to relate or separate two or more things — comparison (showing similarity), distinction (showing difference), analogy (explaining one thing through a similar but different thing), or category (grouping things by a shared trait). Identify the method, not just that a connection exists.

Modeled Example

A text says, "Both towns received the same amount of rainfall, but only one flooded." What method is being used, and what is it setting up?

This is a comparison that sets up a contrast — since the shared cause (rainfall) was identical, the text is preparing to explain some other difference between the towns that explains the different outcome.

A text explains a new policy by saying, "Think of it like a dam: it doesn't stop the water, it just controls when it's released." What method is this, and why might a writer choose it?

This is an analogy, which explains an unfamiliar idea (the policy) through a more familiar comparison (a dam); a writer might choose it to make an abstract policy easier to picture concretely.

Two Towns, One Flood (Part 1)

1. In April 2022, six inches of rain fell over two neighboring river towns, Ashford and Millport, in under eighteen hours — nearly identical totals recorded at weather stations nine miles apart. Ashford's river crested two feet above flood stage. Millport's crested four inches below it. The rainfall was the same; the outcomes were not.
2. The two towns share a similar size, about 8,000 residents each, and both sit along the same river system, separated by a single upstream dam built in the 1950s. Ashford lies downstream of the dam; Millport lies upstream. That single geographic distinction — which side of the dam each town sits on — turned out to explain far more than the rainfall totals did.
3. Millport's upstream position meant its excess water drained directly into the reservoir behind the dam, which engineers had deliberately kept three feet below capacity that spring specifically to absorb an unusually wet forecast. Ashford, downstream, received whatever the dam operators chose to release, on a schedule set by reservoir safety limits, not by Ashford's immediate needs.
4. A hydrologist interviewed after the flood compared the dam's operation to a kitchen sink with only one working faucet: "Upstream is like turning the tap — you control how much comes out and when. Downstream, you're just the drain, and the drain doesn't get a vote."

Two Towns, One Flood (Part 2)

5. That analogy captures a real distinction in the two towns' options. Millport's town council could and did request the dam operators delay a scheduled release by six hours, buying time for its own storm drains to catch up. Ashford's council had no equivalent lever; the release schedule downstream was set entirely by the dam operators' calculations, not by any request Ashford could make.
6. Researchers studying the flood later grouped river towns nationally into two categories based on this same upstream-downstream distinction, finding that downstream towns experienced 60 percent more flood damage per capita than upstream towns along regulated rivers, even when rainfall totals were statistically similar.
7. The comparison between Ashford and Millport also revealed a connection the two towns share despite their different outcomes: both had underfunded their storm-drain systems by similar amounts over the previous decade, a shared factor that worsened flooding in both towns even though it did not, by itself, explain why only one town crossed flood stage.
8. After the flood, Ashford's council proposed a formal notification agreement with the dam operators, modeled explicitly on Millport's existing arrangement — an attempt to close the very distinction between the two towns that the flood had exposed.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What explicit rainfall comparison does paragraph 1 make between Ashford and Millport?
2. What method does paragraph 1 use when it says "The rainfall was the same; the outcomes were not"?
What is this method setting up?

Guided Practice

3. What explicit geographic distinction does paragraph 2 identify between the two towns?

4. How does paragraph 2 connect the towns before distinguishing them? Name both the connection and the distinction.

Guided Practice

5. What explicit detail in paragraph 3 explains why Millport's upstream position helped during the flood?

6. What category of control does paragraph 3 say Ashford lacked, compared to Millport?

Partner Discussion

7. Identify the analogy used in paragraph 4 and explain what two things it compares.

8. Why might the hydrologist have chosen a kitchen sink analogy instead of simply restating the engineering facts from paragraph 3?

Partner Discussion

9. What explicit action does paragraph 5 (Part 2) describe Millport's council taking that Ashford's council could not?

Independent Practice

10. What category do researchers create in paragraph 6, and what distinction does it track nationally?

11. What explicit statistic supports the researchers' categorization in that paragraph?

Independent Practice

12. What connection does paragraph 7 identify between Ashford and Millport that goes against the upstream/downstream distinction?

13. Why is the connection in paragraph 7 important for a complete understanding of the flood, even though it does not explain the difference in outcomes?

Independent Practice

14. What explicit action does Ashford's council take in paragraph 8, and what distinction is it specifically trying to close?

15. Explain how the article uses comparison, distinction, and analogy together across paragraphs 1 through 4 to build its explanation.

Small-Group Work

16. Which is a stronger piece of evidence for the article's explanation: the kitchen sink analogy or the 60 percent damage statistic? Justify your answer.

17. A reader claims the flood happened only because Ashford is downstream. Using evidence from the article, explain why this oversimplifies the article's explanation.

Small-Group Work

18. Compare how paragraph 2 and paragraph 8 both use the idea of distinction, but for different purposes.

19. Explain how the article's use of categories (paragraph 6) strengthens the individual comparison between Ashford and Millport made earlier in the article.

Exit Ticket

20. Why does the article wait until paragraph 8 to describe Ashford's proposed solution, rather than introducing it earlier alongside the initial comparison in paragraph 1?

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. Both towns received nearly identical rainfall totals, about six inches in under eighteen hours, recorded at weather stations nine miles apart.
2. This is a direct comparison used to create a contrast; it sets up the article's explanation that some factor other than rainfall must explain the different outcomes.
3. Ashford lies downstream of the dam, and Millport lies upstream of it.
4. The connection is that the towns are similar in size (about 8,000 residents each) and sit along the same river system; the distinction is their position relative to the dam, upstream versus downstream.
5. The reservoir behind the dam had deliberately been kept three feet below capacity that spring to absorb an unusually wet forecast, giving Millport's excess water somewhere to go.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. Ashford had no control over water release timing; releases were set by the dam operators based on reservoir safety limits, not by Ashford's needs.

7. The hydrologist compares the dam system to a kitchen sink with one working faucet, comparing the upstream town's control (turning the tap) to the downstream town's lack of control (being "just the drain").

8. A kitchen sink is a familiar, everyday image that makes an unfamiliar engineering relationship (upstream versus downstream water control) easier for a general reader to picture and understand quickly.

9. Millport's council requested and received a six-hour delay in a scheduled dam release, buying time for its storm drains to catch up.

10. Researchers grouped river towns nationally into upstream and downstream categories along regulated rivers, tracking the distinction in flood damage per capita between the two categories.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. Downstream towns experienced 60 percent more flood damage per capita than upstream towns, even when rainfall totals were statistically similar.

12. Both towns had similarly underfunded their storm-drain systems over the previous decade, a shared weakness despite their different flood outcomes.

13. It shows the flood was not caused by a single distinction alone; a shared, unrelated weakness (underfunded storm drains) worsened conditions in both towns even as the upstream/downstream distinction explains why only one town crossed flood stage.

14. Ashford's council proposes a formal notification agreement with the dam operators, modeled on Millport's existing arrangement, trying to close the upstream/downstream control distinction identified earlier in the article.

15. The article first uses comparison to show the rainfall was the same (paragraph 1), then identifies the key distinction of upstream versus downstream position (paragraph 2), then uses an analogy (the kitchen sink, paragraph 4) to make that engineering distinction easy to picture, building from data to explanation to a relatable image.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. The 60 percent damage statistic is stronger evidence, because it is a measured, verifiable finding across many towns, while the analogy is only an explanatory device that makes the idea easier to understand and proves nothing on its own.

17. This oversimplifies it because paragraph 7 shows both towns shared an unrelated weakness, underfunded storm drains, that worsened flooding in both places; the upstream/downstream distinction explains the difference in outcome, but it is not the article's only identified cause.

18. Paragraph 2 uses distinction to explain why the flood outcomes differed, while paragraph 8 uses the same distinction to justify a proposed solution, showing the article moving from diagnosing a problem to addressing it, using the same core distinction both times.

19. By showing that the upstream/downstream damage pattern holds true nationally across many towns, not just Ashford and Millport, the categorization strengthens the article's claim that the two towns' different outcomes were not a coincidence specific to them, but part of a broader, measurable pattern.

20. The article needs to first establish the distinction (upstream/downstream), the analogy explaining it, the national statistic confirming it, and the shared storm-drain connection before a proposed solution would make sense to the reader; introducing it earlier would come before the article has built the evidence to justify it.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer